

There is more carbon dioxide in the air today than at any time in the past 800,000 years.

See also

To learn more about people's impact on the carbon cycle, see "How we affect life on Earth" (136–137).

Burning fossil fuels releases lots of CO₂.

Animals breathe out CO₂ and eat plants, which contain carbon.

Fossil fuels build up in rocky layers buried deep below the surface.

Releasing

Living things expel carbon dioxide through respiration (breathing). Burning fossil fuels also releases CO₂. Some rocks slowly release carbon dioxide, too.

Oil rigs drill deep down into the Earth to extract oil and natural gas.

Heating up Carbon dioxide released by humans through the burning of fossil fuels is currently warming up Earth's climate, melting ice and destroying glaciers.



Green energy Unlike fossil fuels, sources of energy such as solar panels and wind farms do not upset the carbon cycle or alter the climate. This is called green energy.

